6. There should be a regular social audit by a district level agency and by a committee of legislators to check whether the funds allotted for the vulnerable social and economic groups are actually spent on them.

7. The state government should not supersede the panchayati raj institutions. In case of an imperative supersession, elections should be held within six months from the date of supersession.

8. The nyaya panchayats should be kept as separate bodies from that of development panchayats. They should be presided over by a qualified judge.

9. The chief electoral officer of a state in consultation with the chief election commissioner should organise and conduct the panchayati raj elections.

10. Development functions should be transferred to the zila parishad and all development staff should work under its control and supervision.

11. The voluntary agencies should play an important role in mobilising the support of the people for panchayati raj.

12. A minister for panchayati raj should be appointed in the state council of ministers to look after the affairs of the panchayati raj institutions.

13. Seats for SCs and STs should be reserved on the basis of their population.

14. A constitutional recognition should be accorded to the Panchayati Raj institutions. This would give them the requisite status (sanctity and stature) and an assurance of continuous functioning.

Due to the collapse of the Janata Government before the completion of its term, no action could be taken on the recommendations of the Ashok Mehta Committee at the central level. However, the three states of Karnataka, West Bengal and Andhra Pradesh took steps to revitalise the panchayati raj, keeping in view some of the recommendations of the Ashok Mehta Committee.



G.V.K. Rao Committee

The Committee to review the existing Administrative Arrangements for Rural Development and Poverty Alleviation Programmes under the chairmanship of G.V.K. Rao was appointed by the erstwhile Planning Commission in 1985. The Committee came to the conclusion that the developmental process was gradually bureaucratised and divorced from the Panchayati Raj. This phenomena of bureaucratisation of development administration as against the democratisation weakened the Panchayati Raj institutions resulting in what is aptly called as 'grass without roots'. Hence, the Committee made the following recommendations to strengthen and revitalise the Panchayati Raj system:

(i) The district level body, that is, the Zila Parishad should be of pivotal importance in the scheme of democratic decentralisation. It stated that "the district is the proper unit for planning and development and the Zila Parishad should become the principal body for management of all development programmes which can be handled at that level."

(ii) The Panchayati Raj institutions at the district and lower levels should be assigned an important role with respect to planning, implementation and monitoring of rural development programmes.